

The Multiplicity of Meaning
Lecture 1: The Thesis of Plural Signification
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1 Introduction

Plural Signification Almost always, when x bears a semantic relation¹ to y , x bears that relation to many other entities similar to y .

¹ ‘Semantic relations’ include speech act relations (*saying, asserting, telling, claiming, suggesting, whispering, ...*); mental relations (*knowing, believing, judging, hoping, being confident in, consciously entertaining*) and narrowly semantic relations (*expressing, meaning, denoting, referring to...*). Relations like *being the conjunction of everything asserted by* had better not count!

2 Intuitions

Some plausible cases where words express several fairly similar properties:

Are Jaffa Cakes <i>biscuits</i> ? ²	Are hamburgers <i>sandwiches</i> ?
Is chilli <i>soup</i> ? ³	Are muffins <i>cakes</i> ?
Is herbal tea <i>tea</i> ?	Is a cheese course <i>dessert</i> ?
Are cucumbers <i>fruit</i> ?	Are cucumbers <i>vegetables</i> ?
Is oat milk <i>milk</i> ?	Are plants <i>creatures</i> ?
Are lynxes <i>cats</i> ?	Are human beings <i>animals</i> ?
Do octopuses have <i>legs</i> ?	Are sporks <i>spoons</i> ?
Are cardigans <i>sweaters</i> ?	Is paddling a canoe <i>rowing</i> it?
Are watercolours <i>drawings</i> ?	Is cardboard <i>paper</i> ?
Are iPads <i>computers</i> ?	Are most philosophers <i>writers</i> ?
Are APA comments <i>talks</i> ?	Are glasses <i>cups</i> ? ⁴
Are building societies <i>banks</i> ? ⁵	Are lake-edges <i>banks</i> ?

In each case, there are some “specialized” uses that assume a ‘yes’ answer, some that assume a ‘no’ answer, and some “indifferent” uses where the speaker isn’t disposed towards either.

- The different “specialized” uses refer to different properties; “indifferent” uses refer to all of them.
- Such examples suggests that many words express sufficiently many properties than it would make sense to try to list in a dictionary.
- Hard to resist saying that, e.g., ‘heap’ expresses a whole spectrum of properties—enough that any number between the minimal grain-counts for two of them is the minimal grain-count for a third.

²The UK’s VAT tribunal says Jaffa Cakes aren’t biscuits: <https://www.gov.uk/hmrc-internal-manuals/vat-food/vfood6260>. ³For a thorough investigation of the question ‘What makes soup soup?’, see <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Y1HVTNxwt7w>. ⁴See Manley 2009. ⁵See Kearns and Magidor 2008.

- *Claim: being vague* is expressing multiple things; or, sufficiently many sufficiently similar things.

Reminder: words like 'express', 'say', etc. are vague. I think that when I say, e.g., 'Expressing is one-many', I refer to many relations, and say something true of each of them.

3 Objections

Objection One

Pluralism about *expressing* conflicts with the Unique Disquotational Meaning Schema:

UDE 'A' uniquely expresses A.

Response: (i) The schema is inconsistent. (ii) It rules out the least controversial cases of ambiguity like that of 'tank'.

Objection Two

Pluralism about *expressing* conflicts with the Disquotational Truth Schema:

DT 'P' is true if and only if P.

Gloss: Whether a sentence is true depends on what it expresses, so if a sentence and its negation both express a mixture of truths and falsehoods, both or neither are true. DT rules this out.

Response: (i) The schema is inconsistent. (ii) The practice of applying 'true' to sentences is an unfortunate philosopher's invention.

Don't say this: 'There is no single thing that is the property of being a tank: there are only the properties of being a container-tank and being a vehicle-tank'.
Get used to this: 'There is a single thing that is the property of being a tank, and it's expressed by "tank", although it's not the only property expressed by "tank"'.
"

Objection Three⁶

Pluralism about *saying* conflicts with the following principles about truth and falsity for utterances:

TDEF₁ An utterance is true iff it says something true.

FDEF₁ An utterance is false iff it says something false.

Gloss: No utterance is both true or false. So by TDEF₁ and FDEF₁, no utterance both says something true and says something false. But on the pluralist picture where utterances often say many things, that should be common.

Response: Ordinary 'true' and 'false' don't apply to utterances either.⁷

⁶ See Andjelkovic and Williamson 2000.

⁷ See Strawson 1950.

But if one wants to introduce them as terms of art, it's fine to break the symmetry between truth and falsity.⁸ Saying nothing false is a common, reasonable goal; saying nothing true is no-one's goal.

Objection Four

Pluralism requires positing pervasive error in ordinary speeches⁹ involving counting the relata of semantic relations.

Response: Such speeches generally involve drastic contextual quantifier-domain restriction.

4 Some not-entirely-successful arguments

Argument One¹⁰

When y is one of many entities that are extremely similar (in themselves and in their relations to x), it would require extraordinary powers of discrimination for x to bear any ordinary relation to y without bearing that relation to any of those similar entities.

Response: While this is right for some relations like *touching*, it is completely wrong for many others. For example, the *advising* relation can only hold between people, although wherever there is a person there are innumerable many extremely similar non-people.¹¹

Argument Two

Since a single indifferent use can be correctly indirectly reported using several different non-indifferent uses of the speaker's words¹², indifferent uses involve saying multiple things.

Unpromising response: We're taking liberties; the speech reports aren't literally true.

Workable response: Speech act verbs like 'say' vary with the other words: indifferent uses of 'There are cups' uniquely say₁ that there are cups₁ and uniquely say₂ that there are cups₂.

Argument Three

Pluralism is needed to explain forced-choice variability.

⁸ For example, by adopting
TDEF₂ An utterance is true iff everything it says is true.
or, better:
TDEF₃ An utterance is true iff it says something and everything it says is true.

⁹ 'The only thing I said was that it was raining'; 'I only told her three of the four things you told me'.

¹⁰ See Unger 1980.

¹¹ The arguments against this claim rely on premises that are no better than 'Everything extremely similar to a heap is a heap', which is refuted by the Sorites paradox.

¹² There are clean cups in the dishwasher.
... — You said there were clean cups in the dishwasher, but you were wrong: in fact every cup in the house was dirty, so I decided to put have a glass of orange juice instead.
... — You said there were clean cups in the dishwasher, but you were wrong, so I took this one from the cupboard, and put orange juice in it.

Gloss: Sometimes even well-informed speakers are averse to giving flat ‘yes’ and ‘no’ answers to a yes-no question. They prefer to *hedge*, often by offering more detail.¹³ But when for some reason saying ‘yes’ and saying ‘no’ are the only acceptable options, different speakers break different ways. This *forced-choice variability* persists even when the speakers are very well-informed and co-operative (motivated just by a desire to inform rather than mislead).

This is mysterious if there only one proposition *p* expressed, shouldn’t the policy *say ‘yes’ if p and ‘no’ if not-p* be the best way for co-operative speakers to achieve their goals, so if the speakers are all relevantly well-informed, they would all follow it and thus all say the same thing?

*“Epistemicist” response:*¹⁴ There is a single proposition expressed (asserted, meant...), but no ordinary speakers, even well-informed ones, can know whether it’s true.

– This seems deeply implausible!¹⁵

Alternative response: There is only one proposition expressed; but speakers don’t *care* any more about avoiding sentences that *express* falsehoods than about avoiding sentences that bear any of many other one-one relations to falsehoods.

– This is workable; but it concedes pluralism in the case of relations like *caring about*.

¹³ Are most philosophy professors writers? — Well, most of them write papers and books aimed at other philosophers, but only a few write for a general audience.

Is your brother bald? — He does have a pretty big bald spot.

Are you in a relationship? — It’s complicated.

¹⁴ See Williamson, *Vagueness*; Bacon, *Vagueness and Thought*. Williamson: ‘We have no idea how to conceive borderline cases in such a way that nothing in them lies hidden from ordinary speakers’.

¹⁵ Two points against the epistemicist account: (i) ‘Yes’ often seems the right answer to ‘Do you know whether *P*?’ even when ‘*P*?’ would prompt hedging. (ii) The epistemicist explanation conflicts with what seemed the best response to Argument Two.

References

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